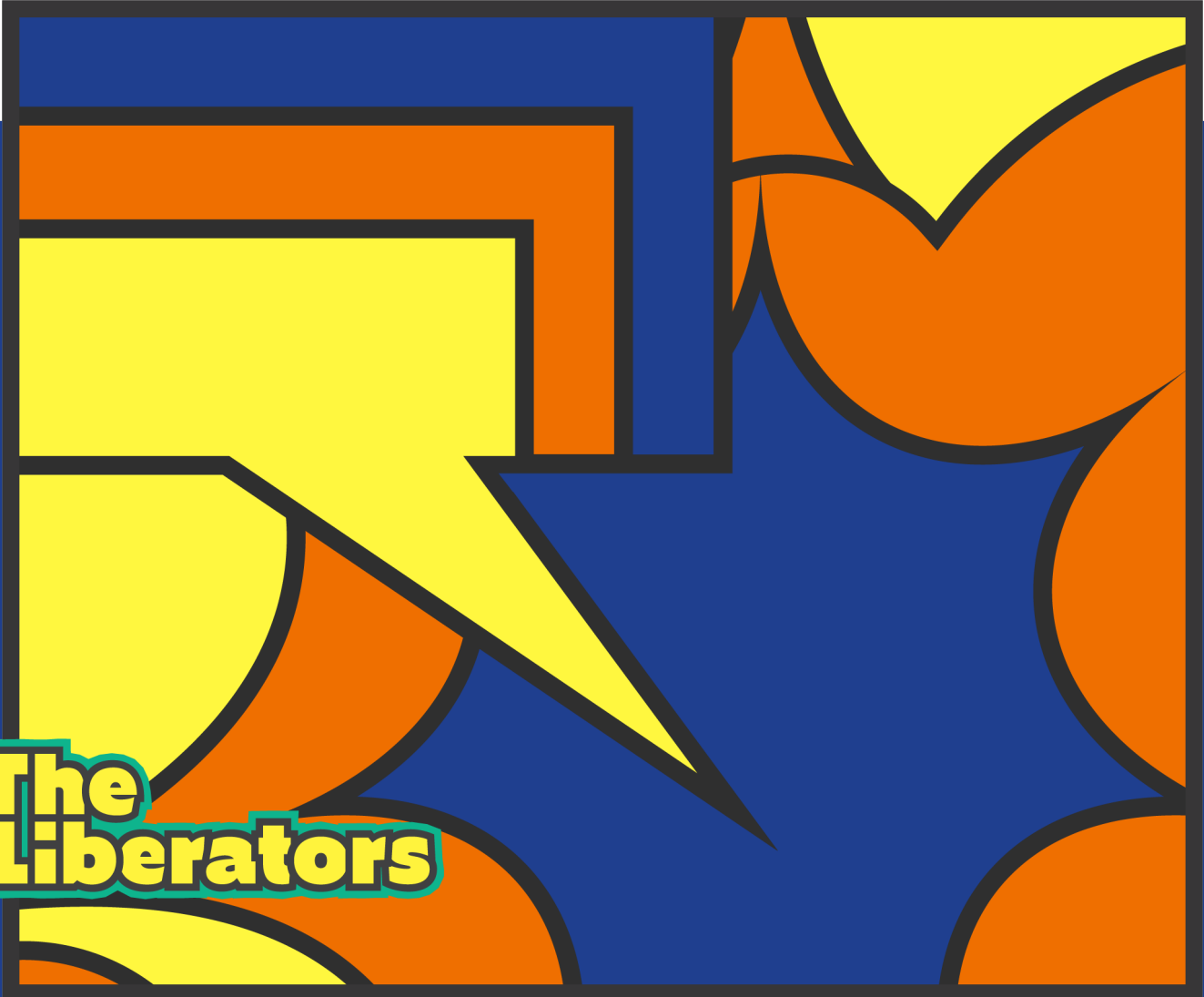


Interview Your Stakeholders And Learn What Matters Most

A do-it-yourself workshop that uses the Liberating Structure "Celebrity Interview" to (re-)connect with the stakeholders of your product



**The
Liberators**

The Purpose Of This Workshop

Hey there,

What is the last time that you've dedicated a full hour listening to your most important stakeholder(s)? For many Scrum teams, this happens only at the start of a new project. Afterward, they are (hopefully) in touch with their stakeholders, but mostly only via email, short online calls, or during the Sprint Review. When a Scrum team lacks collaboration and communication with their stakeholders, it can result in an increased risk of spending time & money on the wrong things.

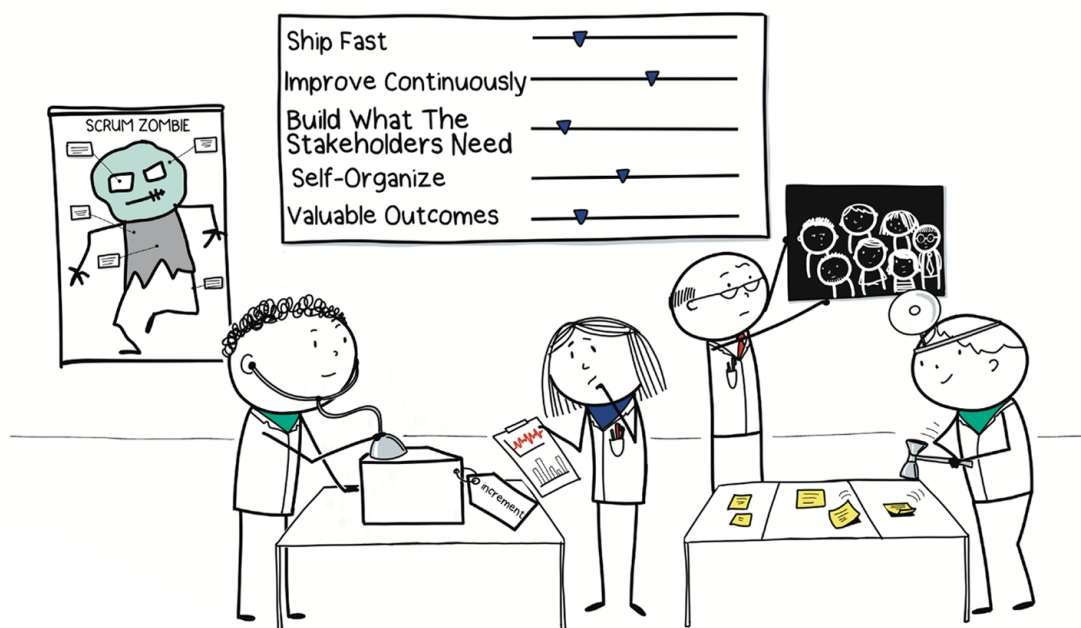
So, it's important to frequently engage with your stakeholders. You need their experiences, ideas, and feedback to learn what to build next. Maybe, while using an early version of the product, an important new insight emerged that impacts the roadmap and Product Backlog. Or changed circumstances in the market require a quick release of a specific feature. You'll only discover this when you closely collaborate with your stakeholders.

If this is something you want to improve with your team, then give this workshop a try. It uses the Liberating Structure "Celebrity Interview" to interview your stakeholder(s) and learn from them what matters most in regards to the product your team is building. Use this workshop as a kickstart of a new project or to refresh ideas & insights at a later moment. It's also a great format for a Sprint Review!

Give it a try, and let us know the results!

Barry & Christiaan

The Liberators



Created by Theo Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
by Christiaan Verwijs, Johannes Schartau & Barry Overeem
zombiescrum.org

Flow

Step 1: Opening

 3 min

Step 2: Prepare Your Thoughts For The Celebrity Interview

  20 min

Step 3: Interview Your Most Important Stakeholders

  35 min

Step 4: Debrief With "What, So What, Now What"

  30 min

Step 5: Closing

 2 min

Total duration

 90 min

Difficulty / Effort

Required Skill



Conducting an interview isn't too difficult, but obviously can be a bit scary.

Impact On Survival



In order to deliver the highest value for your stakeholders it's important to have a good understanding of their wishes, needs, and priorities.

How To Prepare



Group Size

This workshop is feasible from 8 participants and onward, and takes about 90 minutes. You can easily scale this workshop up to many Scrum teams, either by running parallel Celebrity Interviews or by arranging a larger space to conduct the interview.

Intended Audience

We designed this workshop for one Scrum team that wants to involve their stakeholders.

Virtual Delivery

Liberating Structures work well virtually. Here too, they allow you to unleash and involve everyone. What is exceptionally important, however, is that you have the right tools. Because Liberating Structures are fundamentally about breaking down large-group interactions into smaller groups, you need tools that allow you to create subchannels or breakout rooms easily. [Zoom](#) is ideal for this, but similar features are available in tools like [Teams](#) and [GotoMeeting](#). We also recommend a virtual whiteboard where you can collect shared insights, like [Mural](#), [Miro](#), or [Google Slides](#). Even [Slack](#) can work.

Preparation

- Prepare slides or supporting materials for the various rounds and their invitations.
- For the Celebrity Interview, find a volunteer to interview the stakeholders. This could be you, but you may prefer to focus on facilitation.
- Optionally, work together with the interviewer to prepare some questions for the interview in advance.
- If you do this in person, you can already set up an equal number of chairs as you have participants. Optionally, create a stage for the interviewer & interviewee. Put some chairs in front of the stage, or create a circle with both the interviewer & interviewee in the middle.

Resources

- Whitepaper: [Scrum: A Framework to Reduce Risk And Deliver Value Sooner](#)
- Actual stakeholders? Or just your audience? Read the [blog post](#) or listen to the [podcast episode](#)
- Myth: Only The Product Owner Interacts With Stakeholders. Read the [blog post](#) or listen to the [podcast episode](#)
- Blog post: [Why Zombie Scrum Teams Don't Involve Stakeholders](#)
- Podcast: [The Curious Case of the Missing Stakeholders](#)



Stakeholders? Users? Customers? What's The Difference?



In working with Scrum teams we've learned that not everyone has the same understanding about who the stakeholders of their product are. Or they know who they are, but have no idea where to find them or how to connect with them. Often, teams are also confused about the terminology you find in the Scrum Guide: stakeholders, users, customers... what's the difference? If this is the case for you as well, read the blog post we've included below, or try the do-it-yourself workshop ["Discover Your Stakeholders With A Stakeholder Map"](#).

When is someone a stakeholder, really?

It's such a simple question that you can't help but wonder why we're even asking it. The Scrum framework relies heavily on involving stakeholders. And for good reason. You need them to validate your assumptions and to determine what is valuable (and what isn't).

It's a simple question. Still, many Scrum teams and organizations struggle with it. We've visited Sprint Reviews where all the 'stakeholders' present were internal to the organization; people from marketing and sales, an internal product manager, and an opinionated colleague. None of them were either using or paying for the product and its development. We've found that not including the right stakeholders is one of the primary causes of Zombie Scrum.

Stakeholders, Users, or Customers?

When we talk about Stakeholders, are we talking about Users? Customers? Internal or external customers? Product Managers? While some organizations work exclusively for external customers, many organizations also have people inside the organization that should be included in deciding what is valuable. And in other organizations, the term 'customer' is not something that people are used to, like in NGOs and governmental agencies.

For this reason, the Scrum Guide purposefully talks about 'stakeholders' as a placeholder for anyone who has a stake in the product. Like in a betting game — where the word 'stake' comes from — they personally have something to gain when the team delivers and something to lose when it doesn't.

But particularly in Zombie Scrum, we see many examples where the vagueness of 'stakeholders' is leveraged into making teams believe that only talking to internal stakeholders, domain experts, or intermediaries is exactly what Scrum is all about. For them, it's not necessary to talk to the people using the product or paying for it. And that is a huge issue.

Stakeholders help reduce risk

In product development, we want to balance the user or customer perspective with a business perspective. Only focusing on one of them is going to lead to trouble. Yet in virtually all the Zombie Scrum teams we've worked with, the side of the customers and the users were woefully underrepresented. This leads directly to many of the symptoms of Zombie Scrum. And it keeps risk very high.

"Risk" is the keyword here. When you are developing a product with your team, you are investing time and money into building something that you hope will return on that investment. And stakeholders — in particular users and customers — are your natural allies. By going back to them very frequently, as Scrum encourages, you can verify if you're still on track. Are you still spending their money right? Are you still working towards solving the problem they need your product for?

So, including actual stakeholders is the best way to reduce the risk of building the wrong product and/or solving the wrong problems. But how do you find them?

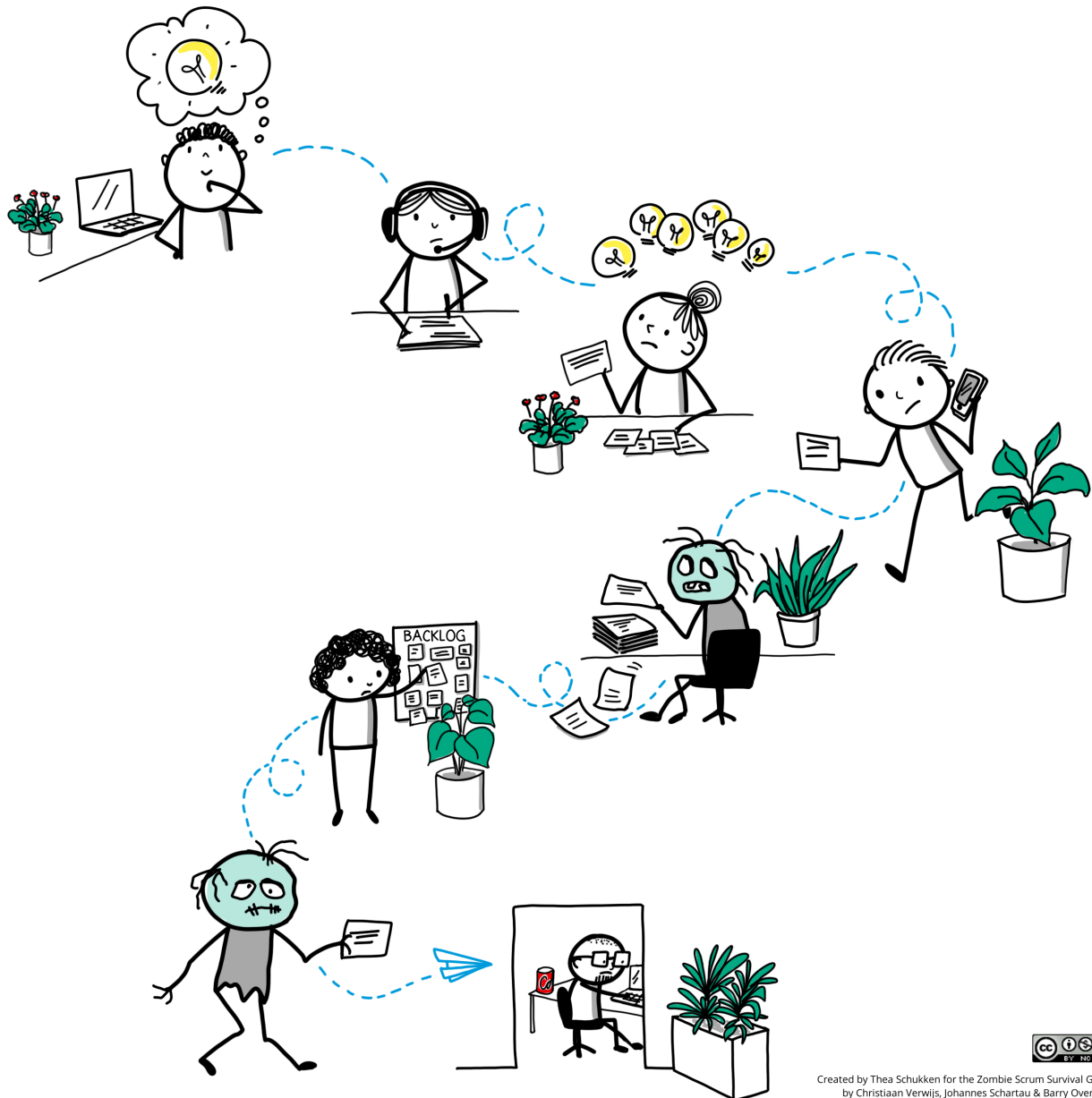
Three questions to find them

So while it is easy to include many people in product development and simply call them 'stakeholders', it is far more difficult to find the people that have an actual stake in your product. We find the following questions helpful to discover if they have a meaningful stake (and either one or more should clearly apply):



- Are they going to use or are they using the product on a regular basis?
- Are they investing significantly in the development of the product?
- Are they personally invested in solving a challenge that your product addresses?

You'll notice that these questions are about value. A stakeholder is someone who helps you decide what is valuable to work on next because it's important to them to get a return on their investment of time and/or money. Everyone else is your 'audience'. This likely includes domain experts, intermediaries, and other people that are interested in your product but have no personal stake in it. You can happily invite them for the ride, but you want to focus your energy and time on your stakeholders. Naturally, this perspective emphasizes the involvement of the people using your product (users) and the people paying for it (customers).



Created by Thea Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
by Christiaan Verwijs, Johannes Schartau & Barry Overeem
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Step 1: Opening

Start at the scheduled time. People who drop in later can jump in then. We always start our gatherings by simply saying "Hi!", followed by our name. We then explain the purpose and start with the first structure. Superfast!



Step 2: Prepare Your Thoughts For The Celebrity Interview

Before we start the Celebrity Interview, we're first going to help the Scrum team(s) prepare their thoughts. The Liberating Structure [Impromptu Networking](#) helps you do so. It's a great way to quickly let everyone share their thoughts and to notice patterns that seem important for the group.

Invitation

"What is something you would like to learn from the stakeholders of your product? What is an assumption you want to validate, or a question you want to ask?"



Steps

1. **1 min** First offer the invitation and give everyone a minute to silently get their thinking started.
2. **3 min** Ask everyone to form pairs and let them share their ideas and thoughts with their partner. If you're doing this virtually, assign people to breakout rooms.
3. **6 min** Repeat the previous round twice more. Invite people into new pairs, and let them share their thoughts and observations while noticing patterns.
4. **10 min** When everyone is back together, ask the participants for the patterns they noticed. Capture them on a shared surface if you want to.

Our Findings

- This round is done without the stakeholders. While the Scrum teams share their thoughts about what they want to learn from the stakeholders, you can invite the stakeholders to make observations and get ready for the interview. If you do want to include the stakeholders in Impromptu Networking, then tweak the invitation in such a way it's more generic and also relevant for them to discuss.

Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- Blogpost: [Rapidly share novel ideas and make personal connections with 'Impromptu Networking'](#)



Step 3: Interview Your Most Important Stakeholders



Now that everyone has loosened up, made some fresh connections, and shared ideas, it's time to learn more from your stakeholders. The Liberating Structure [Celebrity Interview](#) is a great way to do this. By using an interview-based approach, the stakeholders can first share their initial thoughts. Then, the audience (the Scrum team) is invited to ask questions to better understand what the stakeholders consider most important.

Example questions for the interview

"Where and how did you first learn about our product? What set it apart from similar products out there?"

"Can you share one experience with our product that illustrates to you why it is so helpful or useful?"

"What area of the product could be strengthened to make it more helpful or useful?"

"What is a minor annoyance with the product that would make your work with our product more fluent and easier?"

Steps

1. **2 min** Prepare for Celebrity Interview by creating a stage where the interviewer (you?) and the interviewee (the stakeholders) are clearly visible from anywhere in the room. You can either position the interviewer and interviewee(s) in front of the room or surround them with concentric circles of chairs. With a virtual session, ask everyone to switch off their camera, except for the interviewer and interviewee.
2. **2 min** Briefly explain the steps of the Celebrity Interview, introduce the interviewer and interviewee, and share how the product the Scrum team is developing is the primary topic. Also, clarify the expectations of the different roles. The interviewee answers the questions provided by the interviewer. Everyone else is the audience and listens with full attention until step 4.
3. **10 min** The interviewer kicks off the interview by asking questions that exemplify what the audience can ask later. It is super helpful when the interviewer asks for practical examples and potential use cases, instead of abstract

ideas. During this session, the primary focus of the questions should encourage the stakeholders to explain and clarify what they consider important about the product.

4. **10 min** Invite the audience to generate big questions with 1–2–4–ALL and the invitation mentioned above. Give everyone a minute to get their thinking started in silence **1 min**, then pair up with someone else to build on their ideas **2 min** and paired with another pair **4 min**. Ask the groups of four to write their questions down on a (virtual) index card. If you're doing this virtually, assign people to breakout rooms and collect the questions in a chat window or a shared workspace.
5. **15 min** The interviewer collects the questions and sifts through them for patterns. For example, similar questions may appear. Or some questions are more humorous and others are more serious. Based on the patterns, the interviewer asks additional questions to the interviewee(s). It may be tempting to extend the timebox to convey more information. But with the limited attention span of people, less really is more.
6. **2 min** The interviewer closes the interview and thank the audience and the interviewee (the stakeholders).

Our Findings

- The name for "Celebrity Interview" sometimes puts people off. But Keith McCandless – one of the founders of Liberating Structures – always emphasizes that the name is quite purposeful. The "celebrity" gets a podium to share their view, while also receiving tough and difficult questions to sharpen and (potentially) sharpen that view.

Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- Blog post: [Celebrity Interview: Reconnect the Experience of Leaders and Experts with People Closest to the Challenge at Hand](#)



Step 4: Debrief With "What, So What, Now What"

In the previous step, the stakeholders shared their thoughts and ideas about the product the Scrum team is developing. All other participants – the Scrum teams raised questions they wanted the stakeholders to address. In this final step, you'll use the Liberating Structure [What, So What, Now What](#) to debrief together.

Invitation

Round 1: "What have you seen, heard, or observed while listening to the interview? What did you notice? What facts stood out for you?"

Round 2: "So, what does this mean for our team? What does this mean for the product, the roadmap, and the Product Backlog?"

Round 3: "Now what next step makes sense for us as a team? What are we going to do differently from now on?"

Steps

Round 1: Observations

1. **1 min** First individually and in silence, ask people to write down their thoughts on the first invitation. What did they see, hear or observe? Encourage people to remain as factual as possible, taking the perspective of what an outsider would have noticed;
2. **4 min** Ask everyone to form small groups (2–4 people) to share what they noticed. Encourage them to focus on similarities and differences. If you're doing this virtually, move people into breakouts.
3. **4 min** Together, ask each group to share one observation that they feel is most important to their work together. Capture (other) observations on a shared workspace.

Round 2: Conclusions

1. **1 min** First individually and in silence, ask people to write down their thoughts on the second invitation. What conclusions can they draw? What do their observations say about this group?
2. **4 min** Ask everyone to form small groups (2–4 people) to share their conclusions on what seems important. Encourage them to notice patterns. If you're doing this virtually, move people into breakouts.
3. **4 min** Together, ask each group to share one conclusion that they feel is most important. Capture (other) conclusions on a shared workspace.

Round 3: Adaptations

1. **1 min** First individually and in silence, ask people to write down their thoughts on the third invitation. Based on the conclusions from the second round, what makes sense now?
2. **4 min** Ask everyone to form small groups (2–4 people) to share their suggestions for the adaptations that need to be made. Encourage them to notice patterns. If you're doing this virtually, move people into breakouts.
3. **4 min** Together, ask each group to share one adaptation that they feel is most important. Capture (other) adaptations on a shared workspace.

Our Findings

- If you don't have time to include "What, So What, Now What", then another option is to run a quick " [15% Solutions](#)". A good invitation would be: "Now that you've listened to our stakeholders, what new ideas and insights do you

have? What is a good next step for you personally? Or what would be a good next step for our team?"

Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- Blogpost: [Create shared understanding with 'What, So What, Now What'](#)

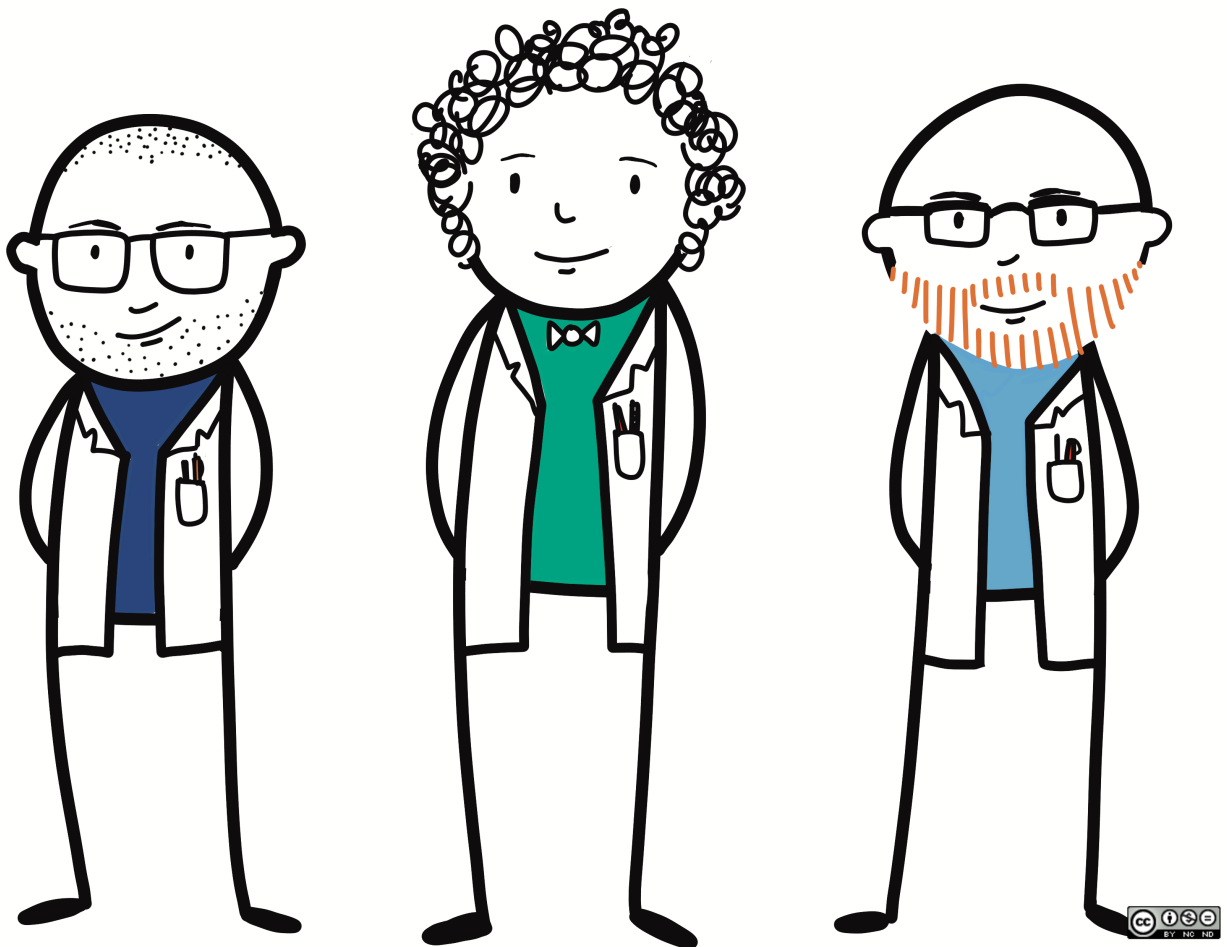


Step 5: Closing

With this workshop, you've made the current state of your product transparent, inspected what this means, and identified improvements to give product development a boost.

Help Us Improve This Workshop

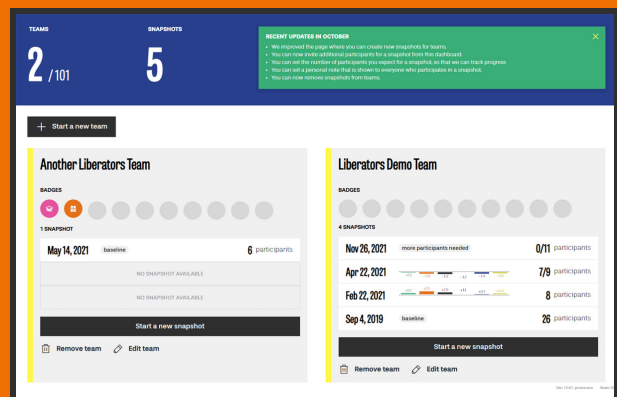
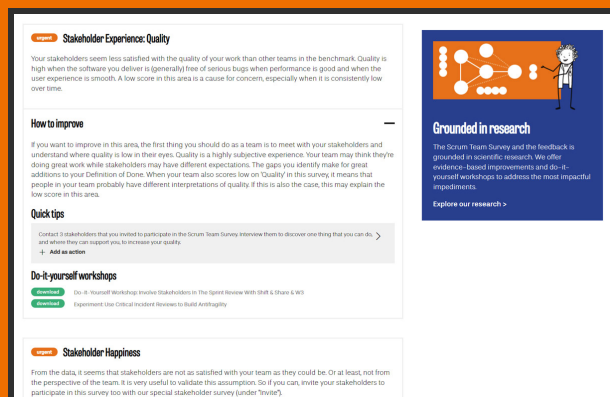
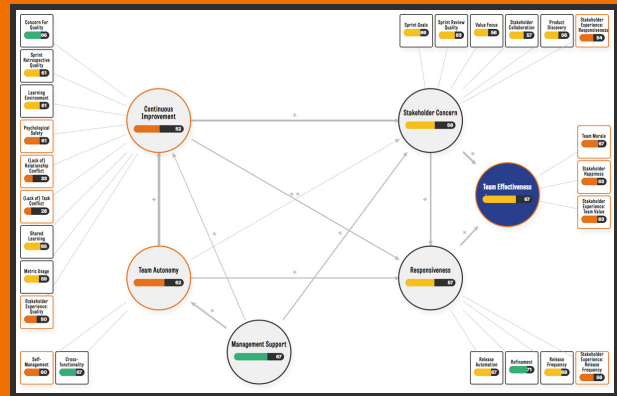
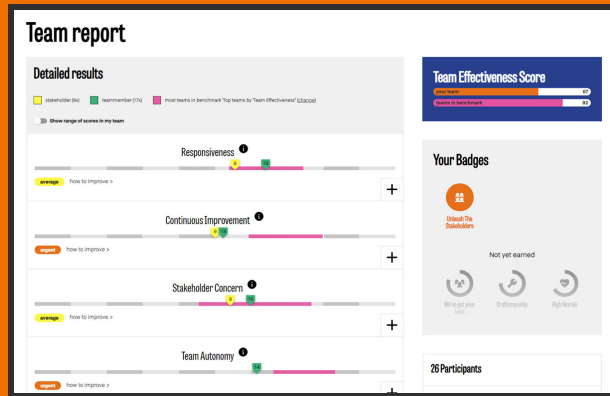
We are eager to learn from your experience with this exercise. You probably discovered much about the flow of the exercise, the use of the invitations, and the impact on the group. What did it make possible for you or your team? What unexpected surprises did you run into? What would make it even better? [Help us learn from your experience by sharing it with us.](#) It only takes a few minutes.



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Want to make your Scrum team more effective? We created the Scrum Team Survey to help. Invite members and stakeholders to a detailed questionnaire and diagnose the results together. You receive tons of actionable feedback based on your results, including dozens of quick tips and useful do-it-yourself workshops. You can use the Scrum Team Survey for free with your team. No account or e-mail address is required. You can also subscribe for more advanced features.



	Essential	Liberator
Invite team members & stakeholders	unlimited	unlimited
Quick Tips for your team per topic	3	unlimited
Recommendations to your team	5	unlimited
Compare your team against different benchmarks		✓
Analyze the range of scores in your team		✓
Receive our personal guidance on how to get started		✓
See where your team improves over time with Team Trends		✓
Support our academic research to help more teams		✓
Pricing per team per month	€ 0	€ 10

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